Lesson 24 material: Introductions

English Stage 3 (C1) · Unit 3: Paragraphs, Essays and Cohesion

4.4: Writing Introductory Paragraphs

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Changes: formatted for print; exercise answers are in the study guide.

Learning Objectives

1. Recognize the importance of strong introductory paragraphs.
2. Learn to engage the reader immediately with the introductory paragraph.

Picture your introduction as a storefront window: You have a certain amount of space to attract your customers (readers) to your goods (subject) and bring them inside your store (discussion). Once you have enticed them with something intriguing, you then point them in a specific direction and try to make the sale (convince them to accept your thesis).

Your introduction is an invitation to your readers to consider what you have to say and then to follow your train of thought as you expand upon your thesis statement.

An introduction serves the following purposes:

1. Establishes your voice and tone, or your attitude, toward the subject
2. Introduces the general topic of the essay
3. States the thesis that will be supported in the body paragraphs

First impressions are crucial and can leave lasting effects in your reader's mind, which is why the introduction is so important to your essay. If your introductory paragraph is dull or disjointed, your reader probably will not have much interest in continuing with the essay.

Attracting Interest in Your Introductory Paragraph

Your introduction should begin with an engaging statement devised to provoke your readers' interest. In the next few sentences, introduce them to your topic by stating general facts or ideas about the subject. As you move deeper into your introduction, you gradually narrow the focus, moving closer to your thesis. Moving smoothly and logically from your introductory remarks to your thesis statement can be achieved using a funnel technique, as illustrated in the diagram in the figure below "Funnel Technique".

Figure: Funnel Technique

The Funnel Technique, or General to Specific, is a very common introductory technique. Other good introductory "lead-in" techniques are the following: the use of a question (that is answered in the thesis); the use of a dictionary definition; an anecdote (short personal story), background information (the "back story" that give explanation of why you are writing on this topic), a striking fact or statistic.

Tip

Make sure your essay is balanced by not having an excessively long or short introduction or conclusion. Check that they match each other in length as closely as possible, and try to mirror the formula you used in each. Parallelism strengthens the message of your essay.

Key Takeaways

- A strong opening captures your readers' interest and introduces them to your topic before you present your thesis statement.
- An introduction should restate your thesis, review your main points, and emphasize the importance of the topic.
- The funnel technique to writing the introduction begins with generalities and gradually narrows your focus until you present your thesis.
- A good introduction engages people's emotions or logic, questions or explains the subject, or provides a striking image or quotation.
- Carefully chosen diction in both the introduction prevents any confusing or boring ideas

2.4: Essay Introductions

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The purpose of an introduction

The introduction of an essay is like a frame for the essay, similar to the frame in figure 2.4.1. That framing helps your audience better understand the argument of your writing by preparing reader for the ideas that are to come in the body of your essay.

(Picture: Blue picture frame with no picture inside)

Figure 2.4.1 A frame. "Single-Sheet Picture Frame" by Michał Kosmulski is licensed under CC BY-NC 2.0

Not only does a good introduction capture your reader's attention and make them want to read on, but it also gives the reader the information they need to understand what you are writing in your paper.

But just because the introduction comes at the beginning, it doesn't have to be written first. Many writers compose their introductions last, once they are sure of the main points of their essay and have had time to construct a thought provoking beginning, and a clear, cogent thesis statement.

Parts of an introduction paragraph

The introduction consists of three parts: a hook, background information, and a thesis:

Hook: Introduce the topic and get readers interested

The purpose of a hook is to provide a general statement about your topic and to engage your reader and get your audience excited about reading your essay. You may begin with a question, offer a statistic, share an interesting fact, tell a story, provide a quotation, describe an event, pose a problem, etc.

Here are some different strategies for writing a hook and example hooks.

- **General Statement**: It is hard to admit that we may be affected by other peoples' stereotypes of us.
- **Proverb:** According to an African proverb, "Until the lion learns to write, every story will glorify the hunter."
- **Quotation:** "We believe the one who has power. He is the one who gets to write the story. So when you study history, you must ask yourself: Whose story am I missing? Whose voice was suppressed so that this voice could come forth?" wrote the author Yaa Gyasi in her novel *Homegoing*.
- **Question:** Did you know that what others assume about you can affect how well you perform on a test?
- **Story:** When I was growing up in my country, I loved giving public speeches. I would participate in speech competitions against children in other schools, and I often one. When I started school in the US, I was excited when we had the chance to give presentations. I knew that I was probably the most prepared student in the class, and that my body language, expressions, and tone of voice could draw listeners in. However, right before I gave my presentation, a classmate said to me, "Even though you are not a native English speaker, I think you can do a good job." I think she meant to be kind, but I was shocked. I went on to give my speech, but I was distracted and did poorly.

Background: Build context for your essay

The background information defines your topic and shows why your topic matters. It provides context for your thesis statement. You may introduce important sources, define key terms, share a brief history, explain the debate, etc.

Here is the background information for a summary/response essay. For this kind of essay, the background information includes a summary:

This is just one of the findings reported by Kristy McRaney and her colleagues in "Stereotype Threat," a chapter in the textbook *The Psychology of Gender*. In this chapter, McRaney and her colleagues discuss a number of studies that examine the phenomenon known as stereotype threat: a situation in which someone is stereotyped, is aware of the stereotype, and is taking part in an activity related to the stereotype (par. 1). According to research reported by McRaney et al., "being aware that *others* believe [the stereotype], is enough to create a stereotype threat outcome" of poorer performance (par. 5). McRaney and her colleagues also look at research exploring *why* stereotype threat impacts test performance, including the commonly-accepted theory by Toni Schmader that preoccupation with a stereotype threat means that the test-taker "ties up valuable cognitive resources" which "impacts the capacity that one has to draw on their memory and to attend and focus on the task before them" (par. 8). Finally, their article acknowledges and responds to criticism of the idea of stereotype threat (McRaney et al. par 9).

Thesis statement: Roadmap to your essay

Your thesis statement drives your essay. It's your controlling idea.

- What do you intend to prove in your essay?
- What is your position about the topic, and your reasons for believing it?

A thesis is generally one sentence, but it can be longer for a long essay. It should present your idea, not an announcement of what you will do (ie, "In this essay, I will give three examples of...."). In the U.S., a thesis statement usually comes at the end of an introduction paragraph. Here is a strong thesis statement:

Overall, McRaney and her colleagues make an understandable and compelling argument for the existence of stereotype threat; the information they present is engaging, seems balanced, and helped me make sense of my own experiences.

Let's put it all together

Here is an example of a complete introduction paragraph, with a hook, background, and thesis statement:

Did you know that what others assume about you can affect how well you perform on a test? This is just one of the findings reported by Kristy McRaney and her colleagues in “Stereotype Threat,” a chapter in the textbook *The Psychology of Gender*. In this chapter, McRaney and her colleagues discuss a number of studies that examine the phenomenon known as stereotype threat: a situation in which someone is stereotyped, is aware of the stereotype, and is taking part in an activity related to the stereotype (par. 1). According to research reported by McRaney et al., “being aware that *others* believe [the stereotype], is enough to create a stereotype threat outcome” of poorer performance (par. 5). McRaney and her colleagues also look at research exploring *why* stereotype threat impacts test performance, including the commonly-accepted theory by Toni Schmader that preoccupation with a stereotype threat means that the test-taker “ties up valuable cognitive resources” which “impacts the capacity that one has to draw on their memory and to attend and focus on the task before them” (par. 8). Finally, their article acknowledges and responds to criticism of the idea of stereotype threat (McRaney et al. par 9). Overall, McRaney and her colleagues make an understandable and compelling argument for the existence of stereotype threat; the information they present is engaging, seems balanced, and helped me make sense of my own experiences.

Identifying the parts of an introduction

Try this!

Here is another sample introduction. Can you find the hook, background, and thesis statement?

Have you ever realized that your first impression about someone was wrong? It is common to have this experience, but it can be useful to understand more about why you thought this. Were your first impressions based on someone's race, gender, general appearance, age, etc.? Chimamanda Adichie describes a similar experience in her TED talk, “The Danger of a Single Story." When she started to write her writing was only influenced by British and American books that she used to read and she was not influenced by her everyday reality. She thought that all books are the same. Later she read books written by African writers like Chinua Achebe and Camara Laye, Adichie felt familiar with the places and characters in the stories. She understood that people like her exist in stories and that knowing only a single story is a danger and it leads to creating stereotypes. "Single stories" develop from making assumptions about others based on hearsay or the media, so the way to combat them is to increase opportunities for genuine interaction between people from different backgrounds.

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- Introductions: https://owl.excelsior.edu/writing-process/introductions-and-conclusions/introductions/